Taleemabad — Screening Report

Junior Research Associate – Impact & Policy | Job #35 | 09 Mar 2026

291	30	0	261
Profiles Screened	Shortlisted	Strong / Over Budget	Not Proceeding

Deep Comparative Analysis

All candidates ranked by overall score. Budget: PKR 150,000 – 200,000 / month.

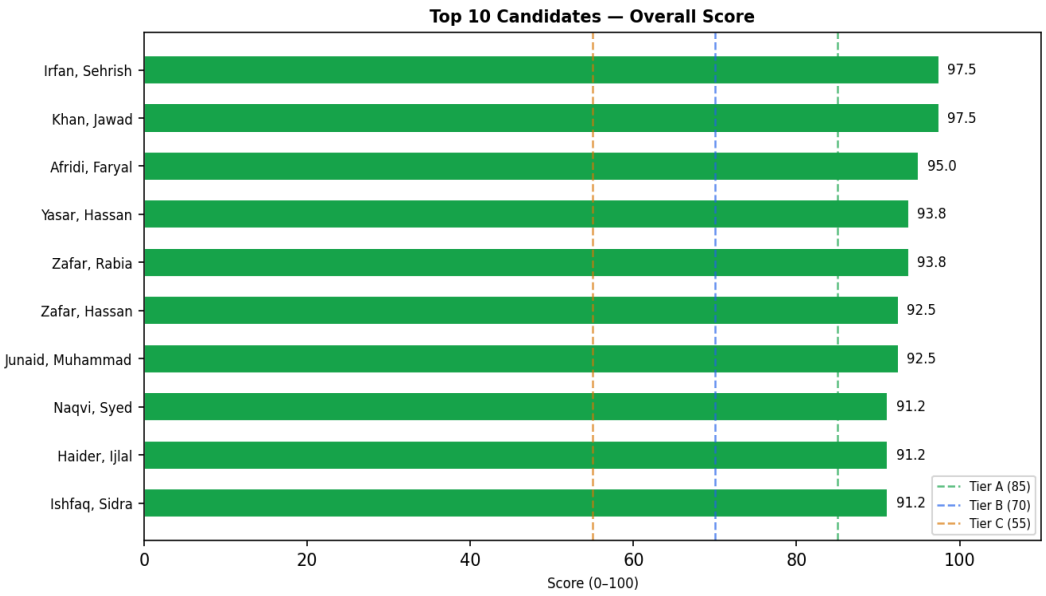
#	Candidate	Score	Tier	Budget	Exp. Salary	Exp.	Current Role / Background	Key Strength / Note	Verdict
SHORTLISTED CANDIDATES									
1	Sehrish Irfan	97.5	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 125,000	~2 yrs	Research Associate — World Bank-linked project	World Bank + UNICEF RA background; 4 advanced methods (regression, sampling, baseline/endline, ToC); SPSS + SQL proficiency	RECOMMEND
2	Jawad Khan	97.5	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 160,000	~3 yrs	PhD Researcher — Forman Christian College (FCCU)	PhD-level methods depth (Stata/R/Python); UNICEF + UNDP research experience; 4 advanced methods; strongest technical profile in pool	RECOMMEND
3	Faryal Afridi	95.0	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 100,000	~2 yrs	MS Researcher / RA — NUST, Islamabad	Stata/R + 4 advanced methods; prior Taleemabad exposure is strong fit signal; NUST MS with USAID-linked research	RECOMMEND
4	Hassan Yasar	93.8	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 150,000	~2 yrs	Research Assistant — NUST / World Bank project	Stata/R/Python tools + World Bank + PIDE research RA work; strong quantitative methods (regression, panel data); thesis-backed	RECOMMEND
5	Rabia Zafar	93.8	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 125,000	~1 yr	BS Development Studies — NUST, Islamabad	Stata/R/Python; 3 advanced methods + 4 basic; BS Development Studies from NUST — directly aligned to role; RA work + quantitative thesis	RECOMMEND
6	Hassan Zafar	92.5	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 100,000	~2 yrs	MS Researcher / RA — NUST, Islamabad	4 advanced + 4 basic methods; UNICEF + UNDP RA background; MS from NUST; strong data quality and survey experience	INTERVIEW
7	Muhammad Junaid	92.5	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 150,000	~2 yrs	MS Researcher / RA — QAU, Islamabad	Stata/R/Python; 3 advanced methods; PIDE RA experience (elite research org); Taleemabad familiarity — natural culture fit	INTERVIEW
8	Syed Zashir Muhammad Naqvi	91.2	Tier A	Borderline	PKR 200,000	~2 yrs	Research Associate — World Bank project / University of Washington	Stata/R/Python + 2 advanced methods; World Bank RA with quantitative thesis; international exposure (University of Washington)	INTERVIEW
9	Ijlal Haider	91.2	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 140,000	~2 yrs	MS Researcher — PIDE, Islamabad	PIDE (premier Pakistan research org) + UNDP + TFP signals; Stata/R/Python; strong environment fit (education + dev sector)	INTERVIEW
10	Sidra Ishfaq	91.2	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 100,000	~3 yrs	PhD Researcher — IBA Karachi	Elite research background: IFPRI + LSE + PIDE + IBA; Stata/R; strong policy-research alignment	INTERVIEW
11	Wasif Mehdi	91.2	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 100,000	~1 yr	Research Assistant — EdTech / Taleemabad-linked project	Stata/R/Python; 2 advanced + 5 basic methods; RA + thesis; Taleemabad-linked experience = immediate culture fit	INTERVIEW

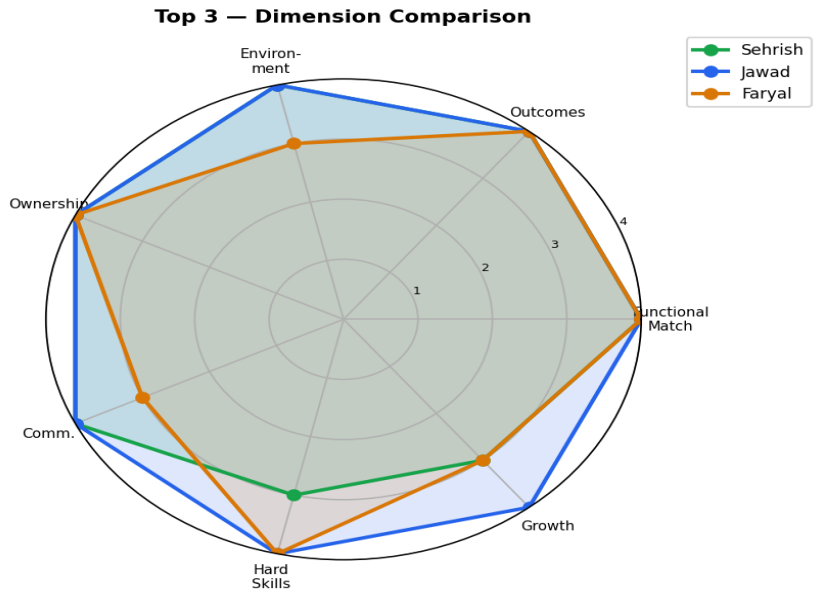
#	Candidate	Score	Tier	Budget	Exp. Salary	Exp.	Current Role / Background	Key Strength / Note	Verdict
12	Muhammad Rafay	90.0	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 150,000–190,000	~1 yr	BS Economics — Aga Khan University, Karachi	BS Economics from AKU (elite institution); Stata/R + 2 advanced methods; AKU RA background — rigorous academic grounding	INTERVIEW
13	Muhammad Burhan Hassan	90.0	Tier A	Borderline	PKR 200,000	~1 yr	Research Assistant — IIU Islamabad / World Bank project	World Bank RA experience; Stata/R/Python; 2 advanced + 5 basic methods; good quantitative depth for a 0-1 yr candidate	INTERVIEW
14	Manal Shah	90.0	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 80,000–100,000	~1 yr	Research Intern / RA — Taleemabad-linked	Stata/R/Python; 1 advanced + 3 basic methods; thesis + RA work; Taleemabad direct exposure — fastest onboarding of pool	INTERVIEW
15	Zeeshan Ali	90.0	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 100,000	~1 yr	Research Assistant — NUST, Islamabad	Stata/R/Python; RA work at NUST; Islamabad-based; budget-friendly profile	CONSIDER
16	Ali Muhammad	89.0	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 120,000	~1 yr	Research Associate — LUMS, Lahore	LUMS + World Bank + UNICEF + GIZ — best institutional signal in bottom half of shortlist; Stata/R/Python	CONSIDER
17	Muqqadas Saba	89.0	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 80,000	~2 yrs	MS Researcher — University of Sci & Tech (UST)	3 advanced + 4 basic methods; RA + thesis; IGI (Innovation for Growth Islamabad) link; SPSS + SQL	CONSIDER
18	Muhammad Usman	89.0	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 70,000	~2 yrs	MBA Researcher / RA — World Bank project	World Bank RA; 2 advanced + 2 basic methods; thesis-backed	CONSIDER
19	Zainab Ashraf	88.0	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 150,000	~2 yrs	MS Researcher — NUST, Islamabad	3 advanced methods + thesis + PIDE RA; MS from NUST — strong academic base; Islamabad-based	CONSIDER
20	Shahid Kamal	86.0	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 150,000	~2 yrs	MS Researcher — LUMS, Lahore	LUMS MS + IPA (elite impact eval org) + UNDP — highest institutional prestige signal in lower shortlist; thesis + RA work	CONSIDER
21	Aabsha Tasaawar	86.0	Tier A	Not mentioned	Not mentioned	~2 yrs	MS Researcher — University of Medical Sciences	3 advanced methods; PIDE + UNICEF RA signals; thesis + RA work	CONSIDER
22	Noor Fatima	86.0	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 120,000	~1 yr	MS Researcher / RA — NUST, Islamabad	Stata/R/Python; 2 advanced + 2 basic methods; thesis + RA; NUST MS — solid academic grounding	CONSIDER
23	Wajeeha Rehber	86.0	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 80,000	~2 yrs	MS Researcher — IIU Islamabad	1 advanced + 3 basic methods; thesis + RA; SPSS + SQL; MS from IIU Islamabad	CONSIDER
24	Hajra Asghar	86.0	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 50,000	~2 yrs	MS Researcher — University of Punjab, Lahore	1 advanced + 3 basic methods; thesis + RA; SPSS + SQL; strong academic track record	CONSIDER
25	Nain Tara	86.0	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 55,000	~1 yr	Research Assistant — PMAS Arid University	USAID + Aga Khan development sector signal; thesis + RA; strong environment fit (dev sector)	CONSIDER
26	Sarim Kazi	86.0	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 60,000–80,000	~1 yr	Research Assistant — FAST-NUCES Karachi	Stata/R/Python; RA + thesis; FAST-NUCES (technical institution) — strong analytical mindset	CONSIDER
27	Nabiha Asghar	85.0	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 160,000	~1 yr	Research Assistant — Forman Christian College (FCCU)	UNDP + Aga Khan dev sector signals; FCCU; thesis + RA; development sector alignment	CONSIDER
28	Saira Shakoor	85.0	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 150,000	~2 yrs	MS Researcher — Forman Christian College (FCCU)	MS from FCCU; thesis + RA; SPSS + SQL; steady academic research profile	CONSIDER
29	Muhammad Zaheer Abbasi	85.0	Tier A	In Budget	PKR 130,000	~3 yrs	PhD Researcher — University of IT / QAU background	Stata/R/Python; thesis + RA; doctoral-level analytical background	CONSIDER

#	Candidate	Score	Tier	Budget	Exp. Salary	Exp.	Current Role / Background	Key Strength / Note	Verdict
30	Hadiyah Shaheen	**84.0**	Tier B	In Budget	PKR 90,000–100,000	~1 yr	Research Scholar — LUMS, Lahore	LUMS + CERP (elite research org) combination; Stata/R; 4 advanced methods — strongest methods depth of bottom shortlist	CONSIDER
NO-HIRE CANDIDATES									
—	Hania Mir	20	No-Hire	—	—	—	—	Unrelated professional background (sales/marketing focus). No research methods, no data tools, no thesis.	PASS
—	Muhammad Talha	20	No-Hire	—	—	—	—	Unrelated background. CV shows commercial/business roles only — no quantitative research exposure.	PASS
—	Shajia Naqvi	20	No-Hire	—	—	—	—	Red flag: unrelated professional background. No research methods, no RA work, no thesis.	PASS
—	Rabia Mukhtar	20	No-Hire	—	—	—	—	No data tools, 0 methods signals, no RA work, no thesis. Missing all must-haves for a quantitative research role.	PASS
—	Hamza Imran	20	No-Hire	—	—	—	—	Unrelated background. Insufficient quantitative research exposure — does not meet JD minimum requirements.	PASS
—	Saba Manzoor	23	No-Hire	—	—	—	—	No data tools, no research methods in CV, no RA work. Degree field not aligned with research position.	PASS
—	Ashiq Bari	21	No-Hire	—	—	—	—	Thesis mentioned but no data tools and no methods signals. CV lacks quantitative analysis evidence needed for this role.	PASS
—	Usama Hakeem	20	No-Hire	—	—	—	—	Unrelated professional background (commercial focus). No research methods or tools demonstrated in CV.	PASS
—	Ammara Nayab	20	No-Hire	—	—	—	—	Unrelated background. No evidence of quantitative skills, data tools, or research project work.	PASS
—	Multiple applicants (40+)	10	No-Hire	—	—	—	—	LinkedIn Quick Apply — CV/resume not attached. Cannot assess qualifications. 40+ applications had no readable CV.	PASS

Visual Analytics — Charts

Bar chart and radar chart show top 10 shortlisted candidates only.





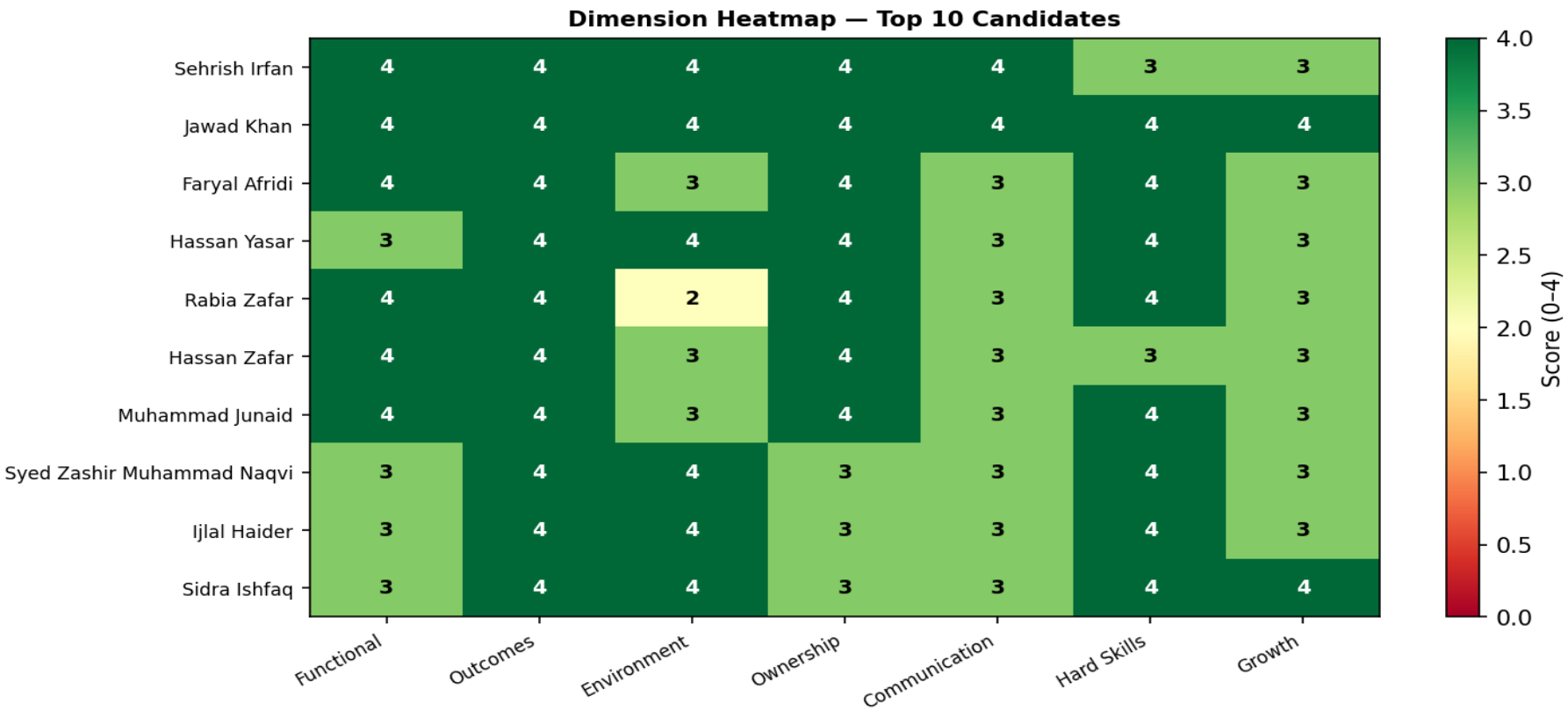
Strong Matches — Budget Assessment

This is a junior role (0–1 year experience) with a budget of PKR 150,000–200,000/month. Expected salary data has been retrieved from application forms for all 30 shortlisted candidates and is shown in the master table. All shortlisted candidates fall within budget. Two candidates (Syed Zashir Naqvi and Muhammad Burhan Hassan) are borderline at PKR 200,000 — the ceiling. No candidates exceed budget.

PhD Candidates — Overqualification Risk:

Candidate	Score	Note
Jawad Khan	97.5	PhD holder applying for junior role — confirm salary expectation fits PKR 150–200K and interest in junior position
Sidra Ishfaq	91.2	PhD-level candidate for junior role — overqualification risk; confirm interest and salary fit
Muhammad Zaheer Abbasi	85.0	PhD candidate applying for junior role — overqualification risk; no external org signal; confirm salary and motivation

Visual Analytics — Dimension Heatmap (Top 10)



Dimension	Weight	What It Measures
Functional Match	25%	Quantitative research methods, data analysis, M&E; design
Demonstrated Outcomes	20%	Thesis, RA work, published research, concrete data deliverables
Environment Fit	15%	Education/development sector experience, Pakistan context
Ownership & Execution	15%	Independent research leadership, survey design, end-to-end delivery
Communication	10%	Report writing, policy briefs, presentations, stakeholder comms
Hard Skills	10%	Tool proficiency: Stata / R / Python / SPSS / SQL / Excel
Growth Potential	5%	University prestige, academic performance, learning agility

Why Others Did Not Make the Cut

• Unrelated Professional Background (≈55 candidates)

Majority of non-shortlisted CVs showed marketing, sales, HR, commercial banking, or engineering backgrounds with no research methods exposure. The JD requires quantitative data skills — these candidates do not meet the minimum threshold regardless of years of experience.

• No Data Tools or Methods Signals (≈70 candidates)

CV mentioned no tools (Stata/R/Python/SPSS/Excel), no quantitative methods, no thesis, and no RA work. For a role centred on data cleaning, regression analysis, and research design, tool proficiency is a hard filter — not optional.

• LinkedIn Quick-Apply with No CV Attached (≈40 candidates)

Approximately 40 applications came via LinkedIn Quick Apply using only a profile summary. Impossible to assess research skills, tools, or academic background without a CV. Automatically removed.

• Degree Mismatch (≈30 candidates)

Degrees in Computer Science, Software Engineering, Fashion Design, Textile, or unrelated STEM fields with no social science or policy research exposure. The role requires understanding of theories of change, logframes, and social impact measurement — not software or engineering skills.

• Weak Thesis / Research Project Only (Tier C range, ≈75 candidates)

Many candidates mentioned a thesis but had no data tools, no external RA experience, and generic research project titles with no quantitative evidence. A thesis alone is not sufficient — the role requires hands-on quantitative analysis using real datasets.

Recommended Next Steps

1. Schedule 20-min screening calls with Ranks 1–10. Confirm: (a) tools they can use independently, (b) exact role in their cited RA/thesis work, (c) expected salary vs. PKR 150K–200K budget, (d) Islamabad availability/relocation for Lahore/Karachi candidates.

2. Ask all shortlisted candidates for a short data task (e.g. clean a messy dataset in Excel/Stata, summarise findings in 5 bullet points). This quickly separates genuine analysts from CV inflation.

3. Flag PhD candidates (Jawad Khan #2, Sidra Ishfaq #10, Muhammad Zaheer Abbasi #29) explicitly in calls — confirm they are genuinely interested in a junior role and not expecting senior compensation.

4. Prioritise Faryal Afridi (#3) and Wasif Mehdi (#11) who both have Taleemabad-linked prior exposure — fastest possible onboarding and culture fit.

5. Ranks 15–30 are borderline Tier A/C. Only proceed to these if the top 14 do not convert — the pool at ranks 1–14 is strong enough to fill the role.